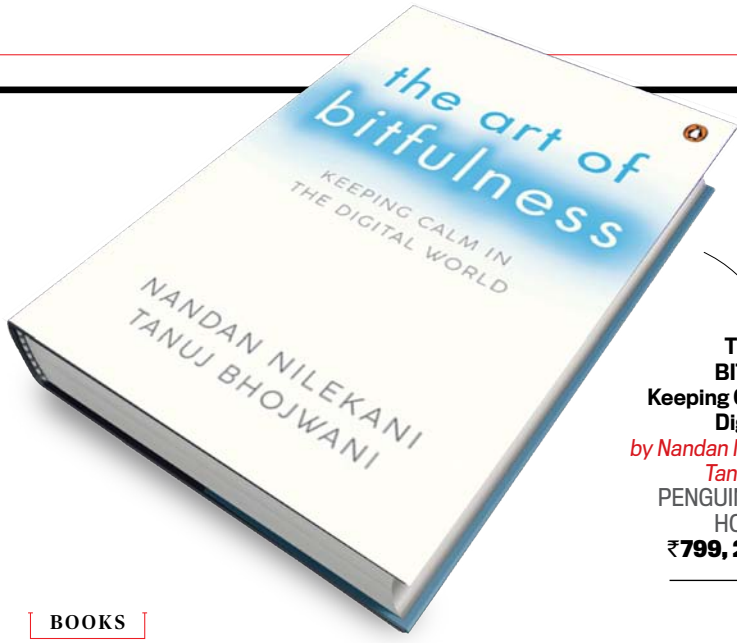


THE ART OF BITFULNESS
Keeping Calm in the Digital World
by Nandan Nilekani and Tanuj Bhojwani
PENGUIN RANDOM HOUSE INDIA
₹799, 236 pages

BOOKS

PRISONERS OF OUR OWN DEVICE

By Prasanto K. Roy

I hadn't paid attention to the curious title when I started reading this book. So when I came across *bitfulness* a few pages down, I asked, what the heck is this? It sounded silly. Did such a word even exist?

The trouble with reading on a phone app is that you can touch any word for a web search. I was instantly taken to author interviews on YouTube, where I also saw and clicked on an air-crash investigation, then returned and touched a link to the book on the Amazon app. There, I found an alert for some coffee beans I had been looking for, bought those...and soon I'd forgotten about the book and the review I'd promised.

The coffee arrived three days later and reminded me of the book, so I ground the beans and brewed coffee, and started reading again: this time on my Kindle device, which has fewer distractions. It took me a few pages to figure out that the book was about those distractions, and about dealing with them. Switching contexts and apps is easy and fun, but it has cognitive costs. It's hard to get back to what you were doing before the interruption. I'd probably check email or Twitter before getting back to the task. Often, I might not get back to it at all. Yet our devices are designed to let us switch rapidly between our multiple identities.

This book is an attempt at fixing the relationship we have with our digital tools, by looking at both sides of the equation. We think of bitfulness as the ability to spend our time on our devices better.

I was sceptical: my inner cynic waved red flags. My Kindle is a graveyard of self-improvement books, and I haven't self-improved much. But the lead author here is someone I've looked up to for decades, and wondered how he achieves so much with, apparently, so few digital tools. Nandan uses his phone, which has no email and no WhatsApp, mainly to make calls. Who does *that*, today? Yet I find he responds fairly quickly to email, and ends up achieving more in a day or month than most people I know of. And he uses and responds quickly to text messages. I don't know anyone else who uses SMS text.

While Nandan got a smartphone at age 55, his co-author Tanuj got it at 21 and is a heavy user—including of social media. The ideas and techniques they put forth in this book work for both users, and evidently for everyone in between. Many of the ideas and insights are things you already know—but might still find yourself saying, Oh. Yes. That's it, *that*'s the problem.

Our devices have all the apps we could ever need in every context: one click for email, Facebook, Twitter, any newspaper or magazine, all available at every moment. There's no separation of work from any other context. The lack of friction means that at every moment, the only thing stopping us from getting distracted is our willpower. Like carrying chocolates while on a diet. On the PC, it's the browser. Too many open tabs don't just slow down your computer: they "also act as a reminder of the tasks you need to get done, adding to your stress".

We're designed for really doing only one thing at a time, but our digital lives are designed around our phones' and computers' multitasking ability rather than our single-tasking nature.

And so I started with just a few of the authors' suggestions. Write it down, but scrap the to-do list, putting that instead into your calendar. Block a chunk of time, a fixed time each day if possible, in your calendar for your most important work, without even knowing what that work will be tomorrow or next week. "Time blocking is a stupidly simple method to make time for your goals." Take time to take notes after conversations and meetings, with simple ways to help you find them. Use just three top-level folders for all your files, auto-backing two of them to the cloud.

It's early days, but already I've managed to finish reading the book and squeezing in this review into my busiest week in more than a year, and done a lot more than I have in a long time: so I think some of this works. And I still think bitfulness sounds a bit silly. But this book isn't. It's a rare self-improvement book that seems to work. For keeping calm in the digital world is a really good thing. ■

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